

The South African Digital Literacy Day is an annual observance established in 2024 to promote digital literacy and digital media awareness across South Africa. It was launched on 25 October 2024 by the Library and Information Association of South Africa (LIASA) as part of UNESCO's Global Media and Information Literacy Week. The day is intended to provide a platform for libraries, educational institutions, government agencies and the private sector to collaborate in creating awareness of the critical need for digital skills in the modern world. Digital Literacy Day is observed on the last Friday of the Global Media and Information Literacy (GMIL) Week each year, highlighting its alignment with international information literacy initiatives.

History

The idea of a dedicated digital literacy day in South Africa was developed through collaboration among library and education organisations under UNESCO's guidance. According to LIASA, the inaugural South African Digital Literacy Day (SADLD) was "developed in partnership with the Committee of Higher Education Libraries of South Africa (CHELSA), the National Library of South Africa (NLSA), and UNESCO". The initiative was framed as part of UNESCO's Communications and Information sector strategy to enhance digital, media and information literacy (DMIL) in South Africa.

Although a "Digital Literacy Day" concept was introduced internationally in 2023, South Africa opted to establish its own national observance during Global Media and Information Literacy (GMIL) Week 2024. In October 2024 the City of Johannesburg Library Services hosted a preparatory event at the newly opened Lehae Library (in Soweto) on 24 October 2024 as part of GMIL Week. LIASA then led the official national launch on 25 October 2024 in a virtual event (based in Pretoria), marking the first SADLD observance. These launch events coincided with broader global MIL Week activities (24–31 October 2024) and underscored the commitment of South African institutions to digital literacy goals.

Significance

SADLD was created to address growing concerns about the digital divide and to empower communities with essential 21st-century skills. In LIASA's view, digital literacy is an "essential competency for communities to participate in the modern world". The day's establishment reflects the importance of digital skills in the context of the Fourth Industrial Revolution and the global digital economy. Its stated objectives include promoting and recognising programs that raise awareness of digital literacy for lifelong learning, personal development, employability and entrepreneurship. By highlighting digital inclusion, SADLD also aligns with national development goals and international Sustainable Development Goals related to quality education and innovation. In essence, SADLD serves both to celebrate achievements in digital education and to call attention to ongoing gaps in access and training across South African communities.

Observance

2024

The first SADLD was observed in October 2024 with a series of events and initiatives. On 24 October 2024, the City of Johannesburg Library Services hosted a "Digital Literacy Day" exposition at the Lehae Library in Soweto, featuring technology demonstrations, talks, and activities for youth and children. This event also included the launch of an internet safety campaign (Africa Online Safety grant) aimed at educating township youth about online risks. The following day, on 25 October 2024, LIASA held the formal SADLD launch online. According to UNESCO's listing of GMIL Week events, LIASA organised the "South African Digital Literacy Day Launch" on that date. The launch event and related activities emphasised collaboration among libraries, government, academia and the private sector. South African Digital Literacy Day is slated to be celebrated each year on the last Friday of GMIL Week.

Overall, SADLD's launch received coverage through LIASA and UNESCO channels, but there have been limited mainstream media reports. Statements by LIASA leaders highlighted the day's role in supporting UNESCO's digital literacy strategy.

2025

The City of Johannesburg's Library and Information Services, in partnership with LIASA, hosted the second annual SADLD at the Brixton Multipurpose Hall on 23 October 2025. The event attracted pupils, parents, community members, and stakeholders who participated in interactive sessions on coding, AI, cyberbullying, cybercrime, and other digital skills. MMC Tebogo Nkokou praised the participants for their commitment to digital learning and encouraged continued growth in digital competence. The event formed part of Global Media and Information Literacy Week under the theme "Minds Over AI: MIL in Digital Spaces." The local theme emphasised the role of libraries in providing digital tools and creating safer online communities. It was celebrated during South African Literacy Week.

The event reaffirmed the role of public libraries in bridging the digital divide and supporting learners and citizens in acquiring the digital literacy skills needed in today's world.

See also

List of libraries in South Africa

History of libraries in South Africa

== References ==